MATERIAL

OBJECTS / PLACES / PROCESS ISSUE 01



The work of making

IN THIS ISSUE

Objects have a working life.

This issue follows three ordinary settings: the pottery wheel, the printing workshop and the shared reading room. Each offers a different way to think about how material, tools and people shape a space.

The editorial approach is observational. We look at the sequence of work, the evidence left by use and the small decisions that make a place useful.

04 / At the wheel

A material that answers back

08 / In the print room

The discipline of repetition

12 / A place to read

Architecture for attention

16 / Colophon

Image sources and production notes

Editorial and design: Ayobami. Photography credits are listed with the publication.

Look beyond the finished object.

A finished object is easy to admire and difficult to understand. The surface conceals the sequence of choices that produced it: where pressure was applied, how an edge was resolved, which measurement was repeated, and what was discarded.

A publication can slow that sequence down. A wide photograph establishes the setting. A detail shows a tool in use. A caption makes the relationship explicit. Text supplies the explanation that an image cannot carry on its own.

This issue treats those elements as complementary. Some pages are quiet and text-led; others give the photograph room to speak. The shifts are deliberate. They allow each subject to establish its own pace while remaining part of the same publication.

AYOBAMI / EDITORIAL & DESIGN, OCTOBER 2026



A material that answers back.

AT THE WHEEL / AN OBSERVATIONAL ESSAY

MATERIAL / OBJECTS, PLACES, PROCESS 04

Pressure, rhythm, response.

The wheel makes a circle, but the work is not mechanical. A potter has to judge the condition of the clay, the speed of rotation and the pressure of each hand. The same motion can produce a different result when the material is wetter, stiffer or less evenly prepared.

This is why a finished vessel tells only part of the story. Its shape is the outcome of many adjustments made while the material was moving. At each stage, the maker has to decide whether to continue, pause or begin again.

The photograph on the opening page shows hands near the turning form. It gives a visible point of contact, rather than an explanation of every technique. That distinction matters: an image can record a moment without establishing what happened before or after it.

A photograph records a moment.

It does not provide an entire process.



Quino Al quinoal / CC0

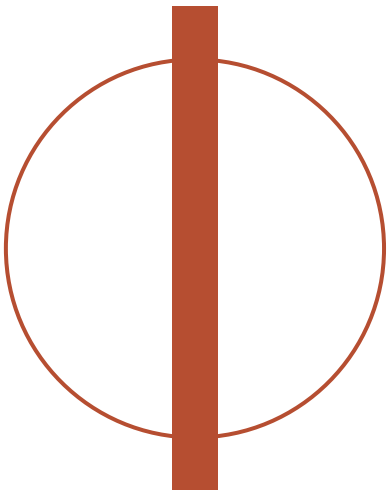
Preparation is part of the design.

Tools tend to receive attention because they are visible. Preparation is less photogenic. A clean working surface, suitable water and a consistent body of clay are conditions for the work rather than features of the final object.

The same principle applies to publication design. A good layout depends on text that is ready to use, photographs with known sources and product information that can be checked. The page should not disguise missing information with decoration.

In both settings, control begins before the most visible action. This does not make the work predictable. It gives the maker a more reliable starting point from which to respond.

What a surface can tell us.



CONTACT / CONTEXT / INTERPRETATION

Native graphic study; not a reconstruction of a making technique.

Reading the surface. Marks on a vessel can reveal contact, but they need context. A line may be intentional, incidental or the result of a later process. It is tempting to turn every visible irregularity into a story about craftsmanship; careful observation resists that shortcut. A useful editorial page leaves room for uncertainty. The caption can say what the photograph shows. The essay can explain a general principle. Neither needs to invent an interview or attribute a private intention to someone who was not consulted. For this feature, the relationship between hand and material provides the organising idea. Full imagery establishes the subject, narrow text columns slow the reading pace, and the detail page separates observation from interpretation.

The discipline of repetition.



Stefan Bethke / CC BY-SA 4.0

Registration before decoration.

A print workshop combines movement with registration. The machinery may draw the eye, but a successful impression depends on alignment, pressure and the relationship between the image and its support. Repetition makes small differences easier to see.

The workshop photograph reproduced here comes from the Carris Museum in Lisbon. It documents an exhibited printing setup; it does not represent an interview with an active production team. That specific context belongs in the caption because it changes how the picture should be read.

In a publication, repetition has a similar role. A heading style, a running folio and a consistent caption system let readers recognise the structure. Once that structure is established, an exceptional page has something meaningful to depart from.

A system makes variation legible.

Consistency is not sameness.

A catalog may repeat the same product fields for dozens of items. A magazine may alternate essays, portraits and short notes. Each benefits from a recognisable hierarchy, but neither requires every page to have identical geometry.

The distinction is useful when reviewing a layout. Ask which elements must remain stable for comprehension and which can change to support the content. Type size, column width, image scale and white space should work together rather than compete for novelty.

For this feature, a colour-led opener introduces the machinery. The following pages return to white space and readable text. The visual change gives the article a beginning while retaining its editorial identity.



A detail crop of the same workshop photograph.

Inspect the actual page.



ALIGN CHECK REVIEW

Native registration study; illustrative graphic, not a press reconstruction.

The page after the proof.

Production is a sequence of checks. A file can look convincing at one scale and expose a problem at another. Small labels, fine rules and cropped images deserve attention precisely because they are easy to overlook in a dramatic overview.

The useful question is not whether a page looks finished. It is whether its content is complete, its images are appropriate, its text is readable and its intended output has been considered.

A finished object can tell us how it was made. The surface carries marks of pressure, alignment and repeated use. Looking closely connects the whole object with the decisions held in its details.



03 / A PLACE TO READ

Architecture for attention.

Shared space, individual attention.

A reading room has to support more than a photograph. Light, circulation, seating and acoustic conditions shape whether people can remain there comfortably. The room’s visual order is only one part of that experience.

The photograph in this feature records a research room at the New York Public Library in January 2006. Its long tables and repeated lamps establish a rhythm that is immediately visible. The image does not tell us how the room felt on that day, so the writing avoids inventing that experience.

Instead, the page considers a general design question: how can a shared setting give individual work a stable place? The repeated desk positions offer one answer, while the surrounding architecture provides the larger enclosure.



Diliff / CC BY 2.5 / New York Public Library, January 2006

The scale between people and rooms.

An architectural photograph can make a space feel monumental. A plan can make it feel abstract. Neither replaces the practical questions of use: where a person sits, what they can see, and how they move without interrupting someone else.

Editorial design has its own version of that scale problem. A large heading works from across a screen, while body text asks for close attention. A publication has to support both views. The transition should feel deliberate rather than accidental.

For this feature, the opening photograph provides the overview. The text-led pages reduce the pace, and a narrow crop returns attention to the room's repeated elements.

Space needs a purpose.

Space serves the reader.

Making room for the reader.

White space is useful when it clarifies relationships. It separates a caption from a paragraph, a title from an introduction and a table from its explanatory note. Empty area alone is not evidence of refinement.

The same is true of complexity. A dense page can be clear when its hierarchy is strong. A sparse page can be confusing when the reader cannot tell what matters. The quality of the arrangement depends on the content it supports.

Across this issue, the editorial system combines consistent type roles with changing page structures. The intention is not to make every spread surprising. It is to give each piece of content enough structure, room and context to be read.

Sources & production

POTTERY: Quino Al quinoal

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